ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

PUNJAB

WHO'S THAT MANN?

The AAP fields a comedian as would-be king, but Bhagwant Mann will need some real space to create an aura of leadership

BY ANILESH S. MAHAJAN



A discerning Punjabi voter with a periscope on the world may see a resemblance between present events back home and what took shape miles away in Italy just over a decade ago. Beginning from the mid-'80s, popular comedian Beppe Grillo had been earning quite a cult following with his merciless broadsides against politicians. By 2009, that anti-establishment spirit coalesced into a political party—Movimento 5 Stelle (M5S)—that began attracting voters disgruntled with the mainstream. Within nine years, the party gave Italy a prime minister. Minus the last bit, anyone can notice an identical spirit behind India's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), but the coincidence became more striking this week when the party announced comedian Bhagwant Mann as its pick for the chief minister's post. Punjab would have its own Tandoori Grillo.

On January 13, the party launched an online campaign to suss out public opinion—apparently 93 per cent respondents voted Mann. Party boss Arvind Kejriwal was leaning towards him anyway, but it was Mann's idea to put it to vote—a patented AAP tactic critics often deride as a crowd-pleasing gimmick. Mann may not have been aware of it, but Grillo too had popularised his ideas and choices through referendums.

Like Grillo, Mann wove a career around the art of satirical comedy. A clean-shaven Sikh those days, he shot to fame with his 1997 album *Kulfi Garma Garam*. He spent the next few years taking freewheeling pot-shots at politicians, bureaucrats, the police and the education system, spinning out breathlessly verbose send-ups that became especially popular in the Malwa belt. With an ideology inherited from his leftist teacher-father, Mann first joined hands with Manpreet Badal, the conscientious objector from the Akali camp. Alas, that experiment, the Punjab People's Party, flopped. Manpreet went to the Congress; Mann took his folksy charms to AAP. Plunging into the 2014 election hurly-burly as the Sangrur candidate, Punjab saw him for the first time in a turban, its 'basanti' yellow hue derived from none other than Bhagat Singh.

Ever since, Mann's wit-laced oratory has earned its own niche in the Lok Sabha. Back home, the relentless barbs helped keep voters healthily sceptical of Punjab's two heavyweights, Parkash Singh Badal and Amarinder Singh, and their parties. If he dared to poke fun even at the powerful Sukhbir Badal and his wife Harsimrat, the Congress finds to its horror that Mann's verbal caricatures are now deployed by all parties against it. A typical Mann take on Congress infighting goes like this: "*Bittu di Randhawa naal nahi bandi, Randhawa di*

ON THE BADALS

" TV channel te doston... Badal Badal Badal, wadda Badal, chhota Badal, chhoti Badal, bibi Badal.. Aaj mausam kharab hai toh bade Badal, aur saaf hai fir wi Badal"

(Punning on the name 'Badal', which means 'cloud' in Punjabi and Hindi, Bhagwant Mann says: "Friends, TV channels only show clouds...Big Cloud, Small Cloud, She-Cloud, Mrs Cloud. If the weather's bad, it's Big Cloud; even if the sky's clear, it's Cloudy all the time.")

ON CONGRESS

" Bittu di Randhawa naal nai bandi, Randhawa di Bajwa naal nai bandi, us Bajwa di Tript Bajwa naal nai bandi, Bajwa di Sidhu naal nai bandi, ate Sidhu di kisse naal nai bandi"

(Reeling out the names of local Congress satraps, Mann piles on the humour with each iteration of the phrase 'X di Y naal nai bandi' –this one doesn't get along with that one– and ends with a classic roundhouse: "...and Sidhu doesn't get along with anyone!")